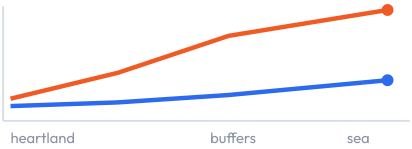
China vs Africa Geography Report

Two geographies, two outcomes: one concentrates people, farmland and security into a fortress heartland; the other divides them with barriers nature and empire left behind.

Overall geography



China concentrates a core, then extends it. Africa stays split.

Population share



Within decades one in four people on Earth will be African. p. 217

Usable geography



Africa is 3× the land; China has the connected, usable share.

Sea vs land barriers



China's navy extends the core. Africa's coast lacks harbours.

01 Heartland & the Hu Line



China's heartland is "the political, cultural, demographic and crucially the agricultural centre of gravity". The Hu Line, from Heihe to Yunnan, explains the disparity of China's population: the fertile east is densely populated...

02 Borders & buffer zones



China's large expanse means it borders many countries, so it wants buffer zones to protect it from instability and secure it early. The buffers deter invaders, which makes it easier to focus on non-militaristic sectors. This is a by...

03 Navy & the South China Sea



A green-water navy patrols China's maritime borders — now the world's largest navy. Through the Nine-Dash Line China claims almost the whole of the South China Sea. That lets it divide countries, control trade routes,...

01 Natural barriers — a negative factor



Africa's geography is a negative factor. Rivers broken by waterfalls and rapids are poor for transport, and the coast has few natural harbours. North and south are poorly connected. Trade and infrastructure are...

02 Borders drawn by colonialism & war



The borders were drawn by Europeans without respect for ethnic groups — Sudan and Somalia among them. That promotes violence, from "Africa's world war" in the Congo onwards, and therefore political, social and...

03 Population growth



Perhaps Africa's biggest challenge is population growth: within decades one in four people on Earth will be African — an extra billion people. The continent will need to adapt infrastructure and increase agricultural...

Similarities

Geography first

Both are continental-scale regions whose fate was set by geography before politics. Both live with buffers and...

Differences

One core vs many splits

China has one fertile, river-linked heartland walled in by mountains and desert, so it became a single centralise...

Which would be bigger?

Africa in area, China in use

Africa is roughly three times China's land area and has a similar population today, with Africa's set to grow far faster. On...

Why does one develop faster?

Unity was cheap

China's geography concentrates people, food and power. Africa's disperses and obstructs, and imposed borders turned...

Quotations from Tim Marshall, Prisoners of Geography. China pp. 52–54; Africa pp. 170, 217.